you that if these political parties, for their narrow interests, allow these persons to poison the whole atmosphere, you cannot keep communal peace in the state.' [8]

The date of 8 April 1982 was fixed for inauguration of work on the Sutlej–Yamuna Link Canal by the prime minister. To avert any untoward incident, the ceremony was held at the village of Karpoori at 11 a.m., four hours ahead of the scheduled time. As a result, it passed off peacefully. Following that, the Akalis launched their Nahar Roko Morcha (stop the canal agitation) on 24 April 1982, in Karpoori.

Two days later, on 26 April, two severed heads of cows were found hanging in two different temples in Amritsar. The Dal Khalsa claimed responsibility. Though the intention was to instigate Hindu-Sikh clashes, it did not have the desired effect as the cow is as sacred to the Sikhs (specially to those in rural areas) as to the Hindus. The only difference is that Sikhs don't consider the cow an object of worship. It appears this operation was planned by someone sitting in New Delhi who did not truly understand the Sikh psyche and executed through an organization originally raised by Zail Singh and others. However, on 1 May 1982 the government declared the Dal Khalsa and Jagjit Singh Chauhan's National Council of Khalistan unlawful. Was this done to publicly distance the Congress from the embarrassing misdeeds of its own creation, the Dal Khalsa?

After this declaration, four persons were killed and several injured when four Sikh militants opened fire in the main bazaar in the town of Patti near Amritsar. This was followed by two incidents on 27 June. In the first, three Sikh militants riding a motorcycle fired on three Hindus in Amritsar. In the second, the propaganda secretary of the Nirankari Mandal, Joginder Singh Sant, was fired upon and injured at Dhabuji village in Amritsar district. On 19 July, the police arrested the president of All India Sikh Students Federation, Amrik Singh (son of Bhindranwale's guru and predecessor Kartar Singh) and Thara Singh, who was Bhindranwale's second-in-command. On 21 July, a rickshaw puller was killed and five others were injured in Moga when Sikh militants hurled a bomb in the main bazaar.